

VARSHA PANWAR



THE SOUND OF MUSIC
(left) Tabla maestro Aneesh Pradhan and (top) young drum artistes from Manipur

It's Jackfruit season in Bengaluru again! The beloved children's music festival of this name comes back in its fifth edition, and this time, they have renowned Indian classical vocalist and composer, Padma Shri Vidushi Shubha Mudgal, curating the talent as Festival Director. "Basically, I get to dream and imagine and hear lots of wonderful music from which I have the challenging task of selecting artistes, repertoire, and details related to presentation," says Mudgal.

Gayathri Krishna, Managing Trustee of the Bhoomija Foundation, which is behind this annual music festival, says, "We called it Jackfruit because the fruit kind of personifies classical music—hard exterior, sticky, and a difficult way to the real fruit that is incredibly sweet! Much like the journey to realising classical music as an artiste!" She adds, "Way back in 2013, Bombay Jayashri directed our first Children's Carnatic Choir, and I was astounded by the talent! Since then, we've been doing a bit of work with youngsters." She is visibly excited about the artistes participating in Jackfruit 2023, which will be organised in association with the Indian Music Experience Museum and held in Bengaluru between September 12 and 17 at the museum and MLR Convention Centre at JP Nagar.

Performers under the age of 17 from across the country are all set to showcase their work to young music aficionados in two stunning flagship showcase concerts conceptualised and directed by Mudgal along with her husband, distinguished tabla maestro Dr Aneesh Pradhan. Chotu Khan (Manganiyar), Rohan Das (Bengali Folk), Dnyaneshwari Ghadge (Hindustani Classical) and Rahul Vellal (Carnatic Classical) come together in 'Singing into the Future'. Dr Pradhan's 'Kamaal Dhamaal' promises a vibrant blend of folk and classical percussion, soulful vocals, melodic instruments and more. Expect to be enthralled by drums from Manipur, dhols, khartals, and dholkis from Rajasthan, ghumat and kansalem from Goa, halgi from Kolhapur, sambal, tuntuna and manjira from Ahmednagar, dhol and tasha from Pune, vocalists from West Bengal, and Carnatic percussion instruments and harmonium from Bengaluru, performed by 38 artistes, including some as young as seven.

THIRTY-EIGHT ARTISTS FROM ACROSS THE COUNTRY—INCLUDING SOME AS YOUNG AS SEVEN—WILL BE PERFORMING AT JACKFRUIT 2023

The icing on the cake is workshops with some of the music world's top names like Shantanu Moitra, Bickram Ghosh and Aruna Sairam. The festival, while emphasising the talent of the artistes, also encourages diversity, with many genres coming together, and opening with a special concert by M.D. Pallavi singing for children with intellectual disabilities plus percussion workshops for visually challenged children conducted by khanjira maestro N. Amrit.

Throughout her career, Mudgal has been recognised as someone with high integrity who uses music as a channel for social change. "Honestly speaking, I have learnt from the many inspiring artistes from earlier generations whose lives and work spoke for their values. They set an example for subsequent generations by using their art to speak about social change and to share their convictions. I haven't really done anything new. I also realise that while I have loved singing for many social causes that I have been associated with, there is a lot more that needs to go into bringing about social change. I mean, I have sung about women's rights and dreams for decades.... Has it really made a change to the status of women in India? Is violence against women going down? And yet, as an artiste, I feel I must continue to sing about issues close to my heart," Mudgal muses.